Coax

By Neil LaBute

Silence. Darkness. YOUNG MAN standing at a sandwich bar, pacing a bit near a round standing table. Bottle of spring water in one hand. He notices us. He carries a manuscript. There should be a distinct difference in the YOUNG MAN's character when speaking to the audience verses when speaking to the YOUNG WOMAN. His demeanor when speaking to the audience should gradually evolve into something quite sinister.

YOUNG MAN: *(directly to judge or female in the audience)* Hey! Hello there, how's it going . . . are you . . . ? . . . no. Sorry. I didn't, I'm looking for . . . doesn't matter. Thanks anyway . . . *He takes a gulp from the bottle; Looks back at audience, smiles.* I don't know why I even said that, "are you . . . ?" because, I mean, look, you're obviously not the person I'm waiting for. *(Points to script.)* Says so right here. I realize that, I must've . . . you know, it's just that whole weird "theater" thing, right? I mean, you can see me, I know you're there, but hey, let's just pretend it's "real," let's all sit here and act like I'm this college guy who's hanging out in some local spot, waiting to meet up with someone . . . but none of it's really happening, is it? I mean, that's what we're taught to believe, anyway. That's the idea. I could never get my head around that stuff, I mean, that kinda concept. The "fourth wall" thing. It's just so . . . odd.

See, I took some theater in college, I mean "drama," that's what they liked to call it where I went to school, "draaa-ma." Big deal, right? Same difference. Anyhow, I took an intro course once, and this sort of little acting thing, improv or whatever, and I was okay, not like some Charlie Chaplin or anything but kinda good. I had no problem getting up in front of people, or pretending to be somebody else.

I mean, think about it, though, the whole thing's confusing. I'm here, I am, I'm right up here, standing in front of you. That's really happening, isn't it? It's true. So does that make me an actor, or just some guy who's waiting to see somebody, this girl that I met? I dunno, you decide. I mean, You don't know me, I could be anybody. I'm just some dude waiting to see this girl that I hooked up with. But you . . . you are sitting there, thinking I'm an actor, doing my stuff, and this is all made up and part of the thing. Wow . . .

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INTRODUCTION

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YOUNG MAN: (Pg 101-114) *He checks his watch.* She's late . . . or is it just not her cue yet? *(Smiles.)* So what's the truth? Actor, some guy? Hey, whatever. You figure it out . . . *He glances off, spots someone.* I think this might be her . . . hold on. *(He gestures offstage.)* Hey! Hello . . . how's it going? *(back to audience)* Really cute. See, we met online, not like in a chat room or anything, I don't really get into all that, sitting and talking about music or whatever, but I'll hang around just outside one, you know, like where you can read the names of who's in there, and then I'll just randomly e-mail 'em or strike up one of those instant message things and that'll usually do it . . . *(Actor shifts focus on-stage and responds as if a YOUNG WOMAN has entered and put her hand out to the YOUNG MAN, who warmly takes it in his.)*

Hi it's great to meet you. *Finally . . .* *(waits for her response)* After, like, four months! Didn't think it'd happen . . .

(back to audience) Seems nice . . . She's cute, huh? Yeah. Really cute, And they're not all that way, believe me. People are usually sorta misleading when you talk to 'em on your laptop. Smarter. Better looking. Or richer. You can easily be whatever you wanna be when you're floating around out there in cyberspace.

She thinks I'm a senior at Milton, studying economics, into John Grisham, hockey, and camping. Which is fine. Let her think that. I do like some of those things, so what's it matter, right? And you, you're still pretty positive I'm an actor, anyway, and this is all some little show that she and I have been rehearsing and stuff . . . but you can't be sure, can you? I mean, not completely. When we walk out of here, a few minutes from now, when I say, "Hey, you wanna go see the sunset? It's beautiful out by the lake 'cause you got a clear shot looking at it back over the mountains there . . ." you'll just think it's a line, right? But is it a line that I read in my script, been practicing, or is it the same thing I say to all the women I

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meet?

(Beat. Actor shifts focus on-stage to the YOUNG WOMAN) And you're even cuter than you said. Seriously. *(waits for her response)* So . . . do you get on there much, I mean, online? Talking to people and whatever. *(waits for her response)* Nah, me either. In fact, I just got my computer, I mean, hooked up to the Internet, like, six months ago, and I just happened to be on that night . . . *(waits for her response)* It's true . . . sometimes I'll get on there, to talk about music . . . and then . . . we just sorta found each other. Setting up times to meet, typing away to each other, wondering . . . this is better. *(Beat.)* So, did you tell your boyfriend or not? *(waits for her response-which is obviously a "No")* Hey, we're just talking, right? It's only coffee. *(Beat)* But I gotta tell you, *I* was jealous, I was, when I heard you were seeing someone. I thought we clicked, really early I felt that, and then when I heard about . . . Jacob . . . well, I just was like, "Damn, this guy's got it going on, this Jacob dude, because this girl is something else. She's special . . . " *(Beat.)* Anyhow, I'll put the violin away now! Sorry, God, listen to me, I'm just really happy you decided to meet up . . . that's all.

The YOUNG MAN starts offstage but stops, looking at the audience. That was nice, huh? I think it went *very* well . . . and now we're gonna take off. I'm gonna do the line about the sunset and then we're gonna take her car and drive up the road to this place I know. And that'll be that. Basically. I mean, ol' Jacob might put up a few "missing person" posters downtown or whatever-might even find that he's a suspect there for a while! *(Laughs.)*

But that's pretty much the whole deal. ***Or*** . . . she and I are gonna go backstage, maybe grab a drink and hope the reviews are good . . . You think what you want. Whatever gets you to sleep at night. *(Looks back at the YOUNG WOMAN.)* I'll give her a chance. I will.

In that class I took, the one I mentioned-the drama one-the teacher told us about what the theater used to be like, not just in places like Paris or wherever, but even here in the States . . . I mean, people used to fight over plays, like, go out in the street and riot and burn places down, start hitting each other right in the aisles because they believed in this movement or

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Romanticism or whatnot. Can you believe that?

I thought that was kinda neat, that it used to mean that much to 'em . . . Nothing means shit these days. So I'm gonna give you a chance. All your lives you've been told to shut up and watch, just sit there, don't say anything; if you hate it, grab your coat and leave . . . but don't *ever* say what you feel. Don't make a scene. Well, that's fine, but it's not exactly very passionate, either.

So here's the deal . . . I'm gonna go back over there, ask her up to the lake, and she's gonna go with me. I promise you; she is. Whether it's in this script here, or I'm just such a charmer, you'll have to work that out, but I'm telling you, it's gonna happen. However . . . if you call out and let her know what's going on, what I'm about to do to her, then maybe I'll let her go. ***Maybe***.

I know it sounds a bit goofy, like *Peter Pan* or some children's show, but if you care about her enough, if you can just, just suspend whatever the hell it is you're supposed to suspend for a couple seconds and think about her, ask yourselves is it worth it to look a little foolish but maybe save that girl, then you say something. Just say it. Out loud right now and maybe she'll hear you. What can it hurt, right? Otherwise, you're always gonna wonder ... *(Beat.)* Now, maybe you'll see one of us on the subway, or at a restaurant or something and then it'll be okay, all some great big lark . . . but if you don't, I bet it's gonna eat at you a bit. Just a little bit.

This is it, your last chance . . . we're not gonna come out for a curtain call, or be outside in the lobby later. This, right now, is it. So do whatever . . . *(When the audience doesn't react- the YOUNG MAN should smile and shake his head, heading back toward the YOUNG WOMAN.)* Ha! You' re worse than I am! ***Cold,*** man ...

(Beat. Actor shifts focus on-stage to the YOUNG WOMAN) Hey, you wanna go see the sunset? It's beautiful out by the lake 'cause you got a clear shot looking at it back over the mountains there . . . *(waits for her response, which is obviously hesitant)* I mean, only if you want to. It's just ... lovely, that's all. *(waits for her response, innocently)* All right, good . . .

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can we take your car?

(To audience.) Well, you had your chance . . . anyway, it's gonna be a really nice evening. I can tell. I know you're heading out after this, but maybe you'll think about it later, tomorrow even, and wonder if I was sh**ing you or not . . . who knows? I love that, though, that uncertainty that you've got now, even if it's only a little. Yeah, I completely get into that!

It's like what I saw in her eyes, just then, that moment when I asked about the lake and she's studying me, noticing the J. Crew and the good haircut and feeling okay that I'm not some Ted Bundy or someone like that and then just jumping off the deep end with a "Sure, why not?" To me, ***that***, right there, is perfect, untroubled happiness. When they look at you, these girls, and they suddenly ***trust*** you. Or you, in your little seat there, doing nothing to help her because this isn't "real" but you want to because she's cute and sweet and, you know, what if . . . ?

At that moment when people're just on the edge, right on the very, very edge of it, that place between reality and illusion, and you coax them, that's all, just coax 'em a touch, and they cross over. And then it's too late. *(Beat)* I love that. Yeah. ***Love*** it. I do. *(Smiles.)* See you around. *He starts off, offers his arm to the willing YOUNG WOMAN and exits. Lights slowly fade out behind him. Silence. Darkness.*

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AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier
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